

Hosting Guide — DigitalOcean vs Hetzner

Where to host, what it costs, and how big a server you need for 5–20 medical-supply customers.

The quick verdict

Host on Hetzner. For the same (or better) hardware it costs roughly **4–5× less** than DigitalOcean, and its German/Finnish data centres give good latency to Sudan. Choose **DigitalOcean** only if you specifically want its *managed database* (it handles Postgres backups and failover for you) and the most beginner-friendly control panel — and you accept paying several times more.

1 Head to head — same specs, real prices

Comparing equivalent **dedicated-CPU** servers (no noisy neighbours), at the specs each customer tier needs:

You need	Hetzner (dedicated vCPU)	DigitalOcean (General Purpose)	You save with Hetzner
4 vCPU / 16 GB	CCX23 — €24.49 (~\$26)/mo 160 GB SSD, 20 TB traffic	\$126/mo 50 GB SSD	~\$100/mo
8 vCPU / 32 GB	CCX33 — €48.49 (~\$52)/mo 240 GB SSD, 30 TB traffic	\$252/mo 100 GB SSD	~\$200/mo
16 vCPU / 64 GB	CCX43 — €96.49 (~\$104)/mo 360 GB SSD, 40 TB traffic	\$504/mo 200 GB SSD	~\$400/mo

Note: DigitalOcean's General Purpose plans also include **much less disk** than Hetzner, so you'd add block storage (~\$0.10/GB/mo) on top. DigitalOcean's cheaper "Basic" tiers (e.g. 16 GB / 8 vCPU for \$96/mo) use *shared* CPU — fine for light use, but a busy neighbour can slow you down.

2 Strengths & trade-offs

Hetzner

- 4–5× cheaper for equal/better specs
- Dedicated AMD EPYC CPU + more disk & bandwidth included
- EU data centres (Falkenstein, Helsinki) close to Sudan
- Fewer global regions; plainer control panel
- You run & back up PostgreSQL yourself
- Email-based support (no phone)

DigitalOcean

- Easiest console + best tutorials for non-experts
- Managed PostgreSQL (auto backups, failover, patching)
- Spaces (S3-style) storage for offsite backups; 1-click apps
- More global regions
- 3–5× the price
- Less disk per plan; "Basic" tiers share CPU

3 What it costs as you grow

Customers	Server size	Hetzner / month	DigitalOcean / month
5	4 vCPU / 16 GB	~\$26 (CCX23)	~\$126
10	8 vCPU / 32 GB	~\$52 (CCX33)	~\$252
20	16 vCPU / 64 GB	~\$104 (CCX43)	~\$504

Over a year at 20 customers: Hetzner ≈ **\$1,250** vs DigitalOcean ≈ **\$6,050** — a difference of roughly **\$4,800 per year** for the same capacity.

4 How big a server do I rent?

Rule of thumb: **~3 GB RAM and ~30 GB disk per 5–10-user company**. Add them up, add ~20% headroom, round up.

Companies	vCPU	RAM	Disk (SSD)	Example (Hetzner)
5	4	16 GB	~160 GB	CCX23
10	8	32 GB	~320 GB	CCX33 + small volume
20	16	64 GB	~640 GB	CCX43 + volume, or 2 servers

- **Save RAM at scale:** run **one shared PostgreSQL** with a database per customer, while keeping a separate Odoo container per customer — cuts memory use noticeably at 15–20 tenants.
- **At 20 customers, split across two servers** so one failure never takes everyone down.
- **Start small and resize up** — on both hosts, growing a server is a few clicks plus a reboot.

5 Every server needs this (whichever host)

- **OS & firewall:** Ubuntu 24.04 LTS; open only ports **22 (SSH, key-only), 80, 443**; install `fail2ban` ; deploy as a non-root user in the `docker` group.
- **Backups:** nightly `scripts/backup_db.sh` per database (it saves the database *and* the uploaded files).
- **Offsite copy:** sync backups off the server daily (`rsync` to Backblaze B2 or DigitalOcean Spaces). A backup on the same server is not a backup.
- **Restore drill:** test a restore once a quarter — an untested backup is just a hope.
- **TLS:** certificates auto-renew (already built into the stack).
- **Monitoring:** watch memory/disk with `docker stats` ; add an uptime check.
- **Versions:** keep the pinned releases in `docs/DEPLOY_PINS.md` .

6 Region & latency for Sudan

Both hosts have European data centres that serve Sudan well (~80–120 ms). Pick the closest EU region:

- **Hetzner:** Falkenstein / Nuremberg (Germany), Helsinki (Finland).
- **DigitalOcean:** Frankfurt (Germany), Amsterdam, London.

Bottom line

For 5–20 medical-supply customers, **rent a Hetzner CCX server in Frankfurt or Helsinki**, size it at ~3 GB RAM + 30 GB disk per company, and turn on nightly backups with an offsite copy. You'll get dedicated CPU and save thousands per year versus DigitalOcean. Reach for DigitalOcean only if you'd rather pay a premium to have its managed database and hand-holding console do more of the work for you.

Prices verified June 2026 (Hetzner CCX post-April-2026 list prices, EUR; DigitalOcean General Purpose, USD). Currency ~€1 = \$1.08. Confirm current rates at hetzner.com/cloud and digitalocean.com/pricing before committing.